whispered to Meena, ‘Don’t say no, it will be impolite. Just pretend that you are taking a sip.’

Poor Meena tried to do as directed, but could not stand the smell. An understanding host walked up to her and took away the wine glass.

‘Never again,’ she said, ‘call me to an exhibition of wine.’

After our return to India, Meena settled back to her routine of temple visits. The only places she went, other than temples, was the houses of my sisters and hers. She was very fond of her youngest sister Usha who was younger to her by more than fifteen years. This sister would be a pillar of strength and consolation for Meena when my arrest and incarceration left her a complete wreck.

I woke up from my thoughts as the car, now taking me home from jail fifty days after the arrest, turned the last curve to my house. I asked Shankar what time it was.

‘Eleven-thirty,’ he said.

CRYOGENICS AND THE CHILLING EFFECT

‘It’s the best drink we’ve made, but it cannot be bottled.’

We were still in the late 1980s and the development of PSLV, which would be launched successfully only on 15 October 1994, after the first failure on 20 September 1993, was set to put India in the club of nations capable of launching its own geosynchronous satellites. But the game was already shifting to heavy satellite launches. And for this, India had to develop its Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV) which needed a cryogenic upper stage engine.

India’s cryogenic dream was born as early as in 1972 when two ISRO scientists Kanaka Rao and Mathew were asked to draw up an action plan, under Gowarikar. But nothing much happened, after Muthunayagam got this group merged into the propulsion group that he headed.